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SAN JOSE

San Jose considers new rules for license plate reader camera data

Some community members and organizations have been pushing the city to get rid of the Flock cameras or rein in their use.

By **Kris Sanchez** and **Marianne Favro** • Published September 23, 2026 • Updated on **September 23, 2026** at 5:07 pm

There's a new push for tighter controls of automated license plate reader camera data in San Jose after a police officer was fired for abusing access. Marianne Favro reports.

San Jose city leaders are moving toward setting new rules for the use of license plate reader cameras after the city's police chief acknowledged that an officer used data from the system for personal use.

Wednesday marks the first step toward creating new rules governing the cameras, which San Jose police Chief Paul Joseph has said are serious crime-fighting tools.

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Among the rules that could be enacted are prohibiting access from non-police devices, strengthening audits and pursuing state legislation regarding unauthorized access.

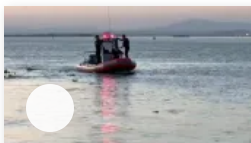
"I want to see us increase the volume and frequency of spot audits," Mayor Matt Mahan said. "These are random audits of individual officers' queries to understand which case was that associated with, was there a legitimate law enforcement purpose?"

Some community members and organizations have been pushing the city to get rid of the Flock cameras or rein in their use. The issue came to a head after it was uncovered that a San Jose police officer used license plate reader data to help a family member facing domestic violence accusations.

In a statement, Joseph said, "These new standards will help maintain trust with our community that the data is being used as intended. They will also ensure that anyone who breaches the community's trust will face administrative and criminal consequences."

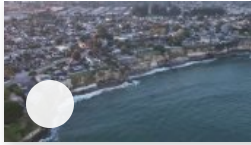
SIREN community organizer Kimberly Woo raised broader concerns about the cameras.

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"Mass surveillance is not public safety, and these cameras are only creating new threats," Woo said. "Again, it goes way beyond just one officer and one vendor and one company because overwhelming evidence has shown, across the country, local agencies and ALPR vendors have grossly mishandled and abused our data."

The issue will go before the city's Rules and Open Government Committee on Sept. 30. Its recommendation will then go to the San Jose City Council.

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